

CENSUS 2011 The Long March

The first phase of the 15th Census to be completed in 45 days has already begun with house listing in most of the states. By next year, Census officials would have visited about 7,000 cities and towns and over six lakh villages to collect data on key parameters.

- The cost of Census 2011 is around Rs 7,000 crore. It is not known whether there will be any additional cost for enumerating caste.
- The last Census form in 2001 had 39 columns. One more will be added this year, if the caste-based census is approved. It is yet to be decided whether the form will identify just caste or category (OBC) as well. This will be done only in February 2011.
- It is mandatory under sub-section 2 of section 8 of Census Act 1948 that "every person whom any question is asked is legally bound to answer that question and to give the information up to best of his knowledge and belief". For not answering or hiding deliberately such information or for denying them the answer, he may be penalised up to Rs 1,000.
- The caste listing, apart from political and social ramifications, is expected to add to the confusion. A caste may come under the OBC bracket in one state, but it could be listed under another category in another state. For instance, Jats have been listed as OBCs in Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh while they are not on the Central OBC list.
- A total of 11,631 metric tonnes of paper will be circulated, including over 64 crore forms and 81 lakh instruction manuals. These would be in 16 and 18 languages respectively and separate for each district.
- To disburse the material, the services of India Post are being used for the first time. The material will be printed at 15 locations, which will then be disseminated to 17,500 charge officers who will distribute it to the grassroot enumerators.
- One lakh forms can be scanned daily at each of the 15 data processing centres throughout the country.
- Provisional figures will be released within 21 days of completing the enumeration i.e. in the last week of March 2011.

by Shyamlal Yadav

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increased. Besides, once the statistics are out, the reservation arithmetic would change."

But numbers do not always tell the whole story or the real story. While the Mandal Commission estimate puts the OBCs at 52 per cent of the population, the National Sample Survey Organisation (NSSO) in its 61st round (2004-05) pegged it at 41 per cent. The ongoing census is expected to throw up a fresh cauldron of statistics which in turn will raise demands for higher reservations and a larger chunk of the welfare pie. It is nobody's case that the Government should not revive something that was given a burial more than eight decades ago. Thousands of crores of rupees are annually spent by the government for the upliftment of the backward classes, for the proper utilisation of which it is entitled to seek a count of the different castes in the country. What is appalling is that as on so many other issues in the last six years, the UPA Government has once again opted for political expediency. At a Cabinet meeting just a week earlier, senior ministers like Chidambaram and Anand Sharma had argued against a caste census. Chidambaram, citing logistic difficulties, had also claimed, "Since Independence as a matter of policy, the question relating to caste other than Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes was not included." He reminded the Cabinet that the previous NDA Government had also rejected the demand for including caste in the census of 2001. Sharma was more categorical and warned that this